

SECURITY WATCH

Excel files used to spread new malware

Reportedly, security researchers at Unit 42 spotted a new custom malware dubbed 'Dudell' which is being distributed via malicious Microsoft Excel documents. The malware is being used by the Rancor cyber espionage group. The group is persistently targeting a least one government in Cambodia with the malware. Researchers found that the Dudell sample is a weaponised Microsoft Excel document which features a macro that runs on the victim's computer. The macro gets executed when the user views the document and clicks on 'Enable Content'. The macro can then locate and execute the data located under the 'Company' field within file properties. It then drops a DD-KONG payload that extracts XOR encoded victim data such as hostname, IP address, locale and other information. It can terminate processes, download/upload files, capture screenshots and give attackers remote access to these systems.

MOBILE WATCH

Xiaomi Mi Mix Alpha

Xiaomi's Mi Mix Alpha is a futuristic 5G phone with a striking Surround Display that wraps around almost the entire phone, barring a vertical black strip at the back which hosts the rear camera and sensors. Xiaomi claims at 180.9 per cent screen-to-body ratio! As far as the specs are concerned, the Mi Max Alpha features a colossal 7.92-inch flexible OLED display. Powered by the Snapdragon 855 Plus SoC, the phone comes with 12 GB RAM and a 4,050 mAh battery with 40W fast charging. The cameras include a 108M P Samsung HMX shooter, a 20 MP wide-angle sensor and 12 MP telephoto lens. There's no selfie camera, and we're guessing, you just turn around the phone to click selfies. The Mi Max Alpha will allegedly be priced at ₹1,99,990 and should release in India on January 19, 2020.



APP WATCH

Five Digital Wellbeing apps by Google



Google recently launched five new, experimental digital wellbeing apps. The first app called Unlock Clock is a live wallpaper for your smartphone that counts down the number of times a user has unlocked their device in a day. To access it, you must download Google Wallpapers. The app has an involuted premise, but really indicates how much you rely on your mobile device. The second app is We Flip, a social ex-

periment app meant for group gatherings. The premise, again, is extremely simple. A group of friends gathered together must all have the app. It detects phones in the vicinity with the app and connects them. Say you're at a restaurant table and want to enjoy an uninter-



ed, quality night with your friends, every person must flip their devices over and set them down on the table to start the 'no phones' session. The session ends when any participant flips their phone to check it. You can then shame this person into

paying for the meal! The third app is Post Box which helps users focus by minimising distracting alerts. Notifications are silenced and they are all bundled and delivered at specific times of the day (up to four). The fourth one is Morph which displays only a preset group of apps depending on the 'Mode' it's on. For example, on 'Work' mode, you can choose to display only work-related apps such as Gmail, Hangouts, or Google Drive. The app switches between different modes based on time and/or location. The last app is Desert Island, a launcher which allows you to pick five 'focus' apps, while the rest of your apps are accessible via an icon on the top right-hand side of the screen. At the end of 24 hours, the launcher will relay how well you did at straying away from the 'distractions'.

Bthere



Bthere is a location sharing and group messaging app that links your friends within the app and offers rewards just for hanging out. It even has a special 'Come Get Me' button in case of emergency situations.

EdPlus



EdPlus is an education app for kids which acts like a lock for apps. You can lock any app of your choosing behind a short trivia quiz. It's a great way for kids to learn about topics while accessing apps.

1Gallery



1Gallery is a clean, simplistic gallery app for managing photos. You can also secure photos and videos with the in-built encryption feature and you can also star important photos for easy access.